Through a Parkdale Lens: Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Services in Toronto: Methodology

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Research Methodology

This study will use a qualitative methodology to explore how newcomer families at one child care centre in Toronto learn about, access, and use or do not use the family support services that the centre provides or refers them to. Qualitative research explores a central phenomenon in depth by gathering detailed accounts from a small number of people (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). This depth is needed because the study asks how families move from first hearing about a service to deciding whether to use it. Information about the number of families who did not submit fee subsidy applications could show that some never applied, but it would not explain how much they understood, what support they were given, or why they did not move beyond a certain step. Only parents' detailed accounts can describe that process, which is why in-depth interviews are the most suitable way to answer the research question.

Context is the second reason for this choice. Qualitative researchers are particularly interested in the context in which participants' experiences take place (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). In this study, context refers to the way the centre shared information, the language it used, the referrals it made, and what each application required. These conditions differ from family to family, even within a single centre, depending on each family's language, work schedule, and settlement history. Because much of this context is carried in what parents report, interviews held on Zoom or by phone can still capture it, although they may miss some non-verbal cues and the parent's surroundings. To reduce this limitation, the interview protocol will ask parents to describe specific moments, such as reading a notice or completing a form, so that the context of each experience is recorded in their own words.

The third reason is meaning-making. Qualitative research aims to understand how people make meaning of their social realities (Mwita, 2022). Services are often designed and described from the provider's point of view, and parents' own understandings may not be included. What an educator means by eligibility or waitlist might not be what a parent understands by the same

word. If the study decided in advance what counts as a barrier or as help, it could overlook what is important to families. Open-ended questions will therefore allow parents to identify what was helpful, what was confusing, and what a service meant to their family, so that the findings reflect families' own interpretations.

Research Design

The study will use a qualitative descriptive design. The goal of qualitative description is to provide a comprehensive summary of events in the everyday language of the people who experienced them, with interpretation that stays close to the data (Sandelowski, 2000). Following this low level of inference, the interviews will be analyzed using thematic analysis at the semantic level, which codes what participants explicitly say (Braun & Clarke, 2022). In this way, the design and the analysis keep the findings grounded in parents' own accounts.

This design will make it easier to carry out the study in a way that answers the research question. First, it allows the interviews and the findings to follow the order of families' experiences with a service. Because qualitative description reports events in participants' own terms (Sandelowski, 2000), the interview protocol can follow each step as parents hear about a service, understand what it requires, seek help, and decide whether to use it. The findings can be presented in the same steps, with each step answering part of the question about what helped or limited families and how the centre responded. Second, the design is suitable for studies that need information directly from the people involved and that have limited time and resources (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024). With four interviews scheduled for Weeks 2 to 4 and a findings report due in Week 7, one round of interviews keeps the project feasible. Third, findings that stay close to participants' words can guide practice (Villamin et al., 2025), as they show educators which explanations and referrals were helpful for families.

Participants, Recruitment and Sampling Plan

Participants and Recruitment

Participants

The participants will be four newcomer parents or primary caregivers. In this study, a newcomer family is an immigrant or refugee family with young children that has lived in Canada for five years or less (Massing et al., 2024). Each participant must (a) be 18 or older, (b) have arrived in Canada within the past five years, (c) have a child enrolled at the study centre, (d) have received information about, or a referral to, at least one family support service from the centre in the past 12 months, such as the City of Toronto child care fee subsidy, EarlyON programs, or settlement services, and (e) be able to participate in English or Mandarin, or with an interpreter.

These criteria are used to choose parents who have recent, first-hand experience with the services that the research question addresses. Criterion (d) includes parents whether or not they went on to use a service, because the research question covers both using and not using services. Each family's account will be explored on its own terms, and families who used a service will not be compared with families who did not, since a sample of four cannot support comparisons between groups.

Three groups will be excluded. The first group is families I worked with directly during my field placement, because a parent who knows me as their child's educator may find it difficult to decline or to criticize the centre (Villamin et al., 2025). The second group is centre staff and their family members, whose employment may make them feel pressure to participate or to speak positively about the centre. The third group is parents who already hold Canadian citizenship. The first sub-question asks what helps or limits families in meeting service requirements, and for newcomers these requirements often depend on immigration status, such as the tax-filing history needed for fee subsidy (Toronto Children's Services, 2025). A parent with citizenship applies under the same rules as any parent born in Canada, so their account would not show how status-related requirements shape access. Citizenship also requires several years of residence, which means that few parents within the five-year newcomer period would hold it.

Permanent residents, refugees and refugee claimants, and people with work or study permits will therefore be included, because each status involves different eligibility conditions that shape families' experiences.

Screening will only ask when the parent arrived in Canada and whether they are a Canadian citizen. Fee subsidy applications require tax documents that many undocumented families may not have (Schmidt, 2026), and more general questions about status may discourage these families from participating.

Recruitment Setting

I will recruit parents from a licensed child care centre in the Parkdale neighbourhood of west Toronto, where I completed my field placement. The centre will not be named in this proposal or in any report, in order to protect families' privacy. This centre is suitable because it already shares information about family support services and makes referrals, so its parents have the experiences that the research question addresses. Toronto's service plan also lists child care settings as access points and identifies tax-filing requirements as a barrier to fee subsidy (Toronto Children's Services, 2025), which makes one centre a useful setting for understanding how city services reach newcomer families. My placement also gives me access to the centre, which makes recruitment possible within the course time frame.

Recruitment Methods

The first step will be to obtain approval from the George Brown Polytechnic Research Ethics Board (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022) and written permission from the centre director. No families will be contacted until both are in place. I will then create a plain-language, one-page flyer and a letter of information and translate them into Mandarin and other languages often used at the centre. The materials will describe the purpose of the study, the total time of about 60 to 75 minutes for one meeting, the voluntary nature of participation, the $25 gift card, and my contact information, so that parents can make an informed decision.

The $25 gift card acknowledges the 60 to 75 minutes that the meeting asks of each parent. However, any incentive may raise concerns about pressure to participate. The Tri-

Council Policy Statement asks researchers to consider participants' economic circumstances so that incentives do not become undue inducements (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022). Head (2009) also discusses how payment in qualitative research can acknowledge participants' time while raising concerns about undue influence on consent. A modest $25 card is unlikely to pressure families into joining, especially because it is not tied to completing the interview. Parents will receive it at the beginning of the meeting and keep it even if they withdraw, and the Research Ethics Board will review the amount. These conditions allow the card to serve as thanks for parents' time and not as an inducement.

The director will share the invitation through the parent newsletter, the notice board, and families' cubbies, and staff will not approach families individually. As in Hardware et al. (2026), someone other than the lead researcher will distribute the invitation to avoid a conflict of interest. Because a notice from the director may still be seen as a request from the centre, the flyer will explain that the centre will not know which parents participate and that participation will not affect any child's care. If fewer than four parents respond by the middle of Week 1, the director will send one reminder.

Sampling Plan

Sampling Strategy. I will use purposive sampling, in which the researcher intentionally selects people who can help to understand the central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Here, these are newcomer parents who arrived in Canada within the past five years and have received information about, or a referral to, a family support service from the centre. The sample will also be a convenience sample of parents who are willing and available at a centre I can already access (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). The purposive criteria determine who is eligible, while convenience determines where eligible parents will be found.

Participant Selection. Interested parents will email, call, or text me directly, and I will follow up with a 10-minute phone call to check whether they meet the inclusion and exclusion criteria. The centre will not take part in screening or selection, so it will not know who has responded. Eligible parents will receive the letter of information and the consent form in their

preferred language and will have at least 48 hours to decide. The first four eligible parents who agree to participate will form the sample, with one adult per family. Other eligible parents will be placed on a waitlist and contacted in order if a participant withdraws before the interview. Selecting parents in the order of contact is practical for a small study, but it may favour parents who respond quickly, and this limitation will be reported with the findings.

Sample Size. The study will include four participants. Qualitative studies typically include about four to eight participants, which allows the researcher to explore each person's experience in detail (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Four participants also meet the course requirement for individual projects. The findings will describe these four families' experiences and will not be generalized to all newcomer families.

Data Collection

Procedure

Data will be collected through individual, semi-structured, in-depth interviews. The interview is my data collection method, and an interview protocol is my tool. The protocol will include open-ended questions with follow-up probes, and its flexible order will allow me to ask for more detail when a parent raises something new. Individual interviews are more appropriate for this study than focus groups, because income and subsidy are sensitive topics and families at one centre may know each other (Villamin et al., 2025). Before Week 1, the protocol will be piloted with one newcomer parent from outside the study to check its wording, translation, and length.

Each participant will attend one meeting of about 60 to 75 minutes at a time convenient for the family. Families can meet in a private room at the centre outside drop-off and pick-up times, on Zoom, or by phone. Parents who join online may turn off their camera and use a pseudonym, as in Hardware et al. (2026). I will conduct interviews with Mandarin-speaking parents myself. For other languages, a trained interpreter who signs a confidentiality agreement will join, so that meaning is not lost in translation (Ilumin, 2023). Each meeting will follow three steps:

1. **Consent (about 10 minutes).** I will review the letter of information with the parent in their preferred language and answer any questions. The parent will then sign the consent form or give recorded verbal consent and will receive the $25 gift card.
2. **Background form (about 5 minutes).** The parent will record their years in Canada, their children's ages, their home language, and the services that the centre shared or referred. The form will not ask about immigration category or income.
3. **Interview (45 to 60 minutes).** With the parent's permission, the interview will be audio-recorded. The questions will follow the steps a family takes toward a service. Parents will explain how they learned about a service, what they understood about eligibility and how to apply, and who supported them, such as educators, settlement workers, or relatives. They will then explain what led them to use or not use the service. Finally, they will describe whether they were able to raise needs related to their language and culture, how educators responded, and what they would like the centre to change. At the end, each parent will receive a list of community supports, such as EarlyON and 211 Toronto.

Participation is voluntary. Parents may skip any question or stop the interview at any time without consequences and will keep the gift card. They may withdraw their data within one week after their interview, before I begin coding it, and this decision will not affect their child's care. Names will be replaced with pseudonyms, and recordings and transcripts will be stored in encrypted, password-protected files kept separately from the consent forms. Only I will keep the list that links pseudonyms to names. Because a small sample from one centre can make people identifiable, my reports will not combine details such as country of origin and home language, and any quotation that could identify a family will be changed or left out (Villamin et al., 2025).

Timeline of Research Study

Table 1

Timeline of the Research Study

Period	Research activity	Main tasks
By December 2026	Ethics and preparation	Ethics approval, the director's permission, translation of materials, and a pilot of the interview protocol
Weeks 1 and 2	Recruit participants	Distribution of the invitation, one reminder if needed, screening, consent, and scheduling of interviews
Weeks 2 and 3	Collect data	Interviews begin in Week 2, with at least three of four (75%) completed by the end of Week 3 and each transcribed soon after
Week 4	Complete data collection	Final interview and the start of initial coding
Week 5	Preliminary findings	Summary of preliminary findings submitted
Weeks 6 and 7	Complete analysis	Semantic thematic analysis completed and the findings report submitted by Week 7
Weeks 8 and 9	Refine findings	Findings reviewed and refined in response to feedback
Week 10	Presentation draft	Draft of the presentation completed
Weeks 11 to 13	Revise	Presentation and final report revised
Week 14	Final submission	Final report submitted

Ethics approval must be in place before the term begins, because recruitment starts in Week 1 and interviews start in Week 2. Each interview will be transcribed soon after it ends, so coding can begin in Week 4 and preliminary findings can be submitted in Week 5. Throughout the study, I will record decisions, changes, and challenges in a reflexive journal.

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